

Comments by Friends of the Ochils on the Scoping Report for the Green Knowes Repowering Wind Farm

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The Friends of the Ochils (FOTO) is a registered Scottish Charity (SC022034) founded in 1992. Its aims are to promote and conserve the landscape, natural beauty and wildlife of the Ochils and to protect and conserve the historical and social character of the surrounding communities; to promote the implementation of good planning policies appropriate to the objectives of the Association; to support responsible and well behaved public access to the Ochils consistent with the Scottish Outdoor Access Code; and to promote appropriate study of and research into relevant fields of interest pertaining to the Ochils and its local communities .

For nearly 20 years it has responded to the many planning applications for windfarms and individual turbines in the Ochils and immediate surrounding area, often to the extent of participating in Public Local Inquiries as a Relevant Person. In addition, it played a significant role in relation to the Beaully-Denny PLI and in a campaign to oppose sand and gravel quarry development in the Ochils. It also plays an active role in the application process for forest and woodland development in the Ochil Hills

We would ask that the following points are taken into account in relation to the Scoping Report for the proposed Green Knowes Repowering Wind Farm and the scoping questions in particular. We have focused largely on Chapter 5 Landscape and Visual but have also commented on other chapters where appropriate.

Q5.1: Do you have any comments on the proposed methodology, in particular in relation to the LVIA of the repowering of the site.

The methodology requires to reflect the complex windfarm situation in the Ochils. There are operational wind farms such as Lochelbank, Green Knowes and Burnfoot Hill plus extensions such as Rhodders; an approved but not yet constructed windfarm namely Craighead; and applications still to be determined namely Brunt Hill and Windburn. This complex situation requires that issues such as cumulative impact reflect the changing realities resulting from decisions still to be made by the Energy Consents Units. The final scoping opinion should therefore describe accurately the position on the ground which the Scoping Report currently doesn't. For example Section 7.12 refers to the proposed Craighead Wind Farm whereas it is consented, and the approved Rhodders Wind Farm which is actually operational.

We recognize that the methodology into the repowering of existing wind farms is evolving but we welcome that the proposed development will be assessed with two different baseline scenarios – the comparative baseline and the restored baseline. We feel that this is particularly important given that the proposed development is different by a considerable magnitude from the operational wind farm. The differences are particularly significant in terms of the height of the turbines – 180 to 200m for the proposed repowering compared to 95m for the operational windfarm, and the greatly extended layout of the proposed development

Q5.2: Are you in agreement with the proposed study areas?

We are in agreement with the 45 km study area but not the 20 km study area. We would wish to see the study area extended to 30 km (see below).

Q5.3: Are you in agreement that the assessment of effects on landscape character should focus on those LCT s located within 20 km of the Proposed Development?

We would ask that the assessment of effects on landscape character extends to a radius of 30 km and not 20 km. Our fundamental reason for incorporating the wider area relates to the far greater height to blade tip of the proposed turbines compared with the BTH height of the operational turbines. Visibility will be that much greater over a wider area.

Q5.4: Are you in agreement that the assessment of the effects on landscape designations should focus on those areas highlighted as being relevant to the LVIA in Table 5-1?

We are in agreement with all of the designated areas detailed in Table 5-1 requiring detailed assessment or otherwise with the exception of the following which we feel should be scoped in and not out.

Western Ochils LLA – we would wish to see this area scoped in. Phrases such as ‘very limited theoretical visibility’ and ‘Significant effects are therefore unlikely to arise upon the character of the LLA’ suggest that the precautionary principle should apply and the Western Ochils LLA should be scoped in.

Forest SLA – we would wish to see this area scoped in as any visibility of the proposed wind farm from the area would be unacceptable even if they are ‘small shards’.

Q5.5: Are you in agreement that Wild Land Areas in the 45 km study area can be scoped out of the LVIA?

We would prefer to see the relevant WLAs scoped in rather than out but given their proximity to the 45 km limit we defer to the opinion of organisations such as NatureScot on this issue.

Q5.6: Do you have any comments or suggestions in relation to the preliminary viewpoint locations listed in Table 5-4?

Given that viewpoints 1, 2, and 3, are all along the A823 and given the importance of the Glen Devon area for recreation we would ask for additional viewpoints on the summit of the popular local top of Seamab Hill and on PKC Core Path Auch 152 from which all 18 turbines of the operational Green Knowes Wind farm are visible. We are pleased to note that a comprehensive assessment of cumulative effects for both the comparative and restored baseline scenarios will be undertaken.

Q5.7: Do you have wind energy datasets which contain operational and consented aviation lighting specifications to inform the baseline and cumulative assessments?

We do not have such datasets but we are not convinced that the potential cumulative effect of aviation lighting for the Green Knowes Repowering development along with aviation lighting required for the approved Craighead Wind farm and the as yet undetermined Brunt Hill Wind Farm can be fully assessed from viewpoints 7, 9 and 16 detailed in para. 5.2.8. We would ask that consideration is given to including additional viewpoints from which the full cumulative impact of aviation lighting can be fully assessed.

Additional comments

We would ask that the additional comments, observations etc are considered when drawing up the scoping opinion:

Standalone Documents. It is not clear as to why certain documents, detailed in section 1.3 of the Scoping Report, should exist as standalone documents and not included in the EIA. They include a Planning Statement and a Socioeconomic report.

Decommissioning of Existing Green Knowes Wind Farm. Section 3.2.1 of the Scoping Report 'anticipates that there may be some overlap with the decommissioning and restoration of the existing Windfarm and the Construction of the Proposed Development'. We would not wish to see the decommissioning of the existing wind farm overlap for an extended period of time with the construction of the new farm. Therefore, we would wish to see a detailed statement on any overlap period to avoid an extended damaging impact on the landscape of the Ochils.

Q 3.2 Do consultees agree that it is appropriate to scope out assessment of decommissioning effects?

Pertinent to the above paragraph we would not wish to see an assessment of decommissioning effects scoped out.

Q8.1 Do the consultees agree that the impacts described in Section 8.8 can be scoped out?

We would not wish to see the effects on peat scoped out of the EIA given that peat of even a moderate depth can hold a substantial amount of carbon.

Long Distance Walking Routes

In section 5.2.2 it states that: 'Long distance walking routes are all situated at greater distances, typically beyond 20 km from the Proposed Development and as a consequence have a limited association with the Site. This is not entirely correct as the Mary Queen of Scots Way passes through Glen Quey, across the A823 and up the Borland Glen close to the proposed site. Further information below

[| Mary Queen of Scots Way](#)

We trust that the above points are helpful in relation to the Scoping Report.

Stuart Dean. Chair, Friends of the Ochils